

Raptor Center perfect destination



Crepes or pancakes

By Monique Boekhout

If you like wildlife but do not feel like driving too far away from Charlotte, the Carolina Raptor Center is the perfect place for a relaxing, educational excursion.

The Carolina Raptor Center is located in Latta Plantation Park near Huntersville, about 20 minutes north of downtown Charlotte.

The Mecklenburg County park is open to the public for free. Besides the Raptor Center, you can also visit an original 1800s farm house, and there is a lake for fishing and swimming, picnic areas, an equestrian center with horses for trail riding, etc.

What is the Carolina Raptor Center?

The center began on the campus of the University of North Carolina at Charlotte in 1980 after biology student Deborah Sue Griffin became interested in birds of prey (raptors). The center was incorporated a year later as a private, non-profit institution and by 1984, the center had grown so large that it moved to its current 57-acre site in Latta Plantation Park.

Since its move in 1984, many dedicated volunteers have worked hard to construct a nature trail through the woods, building and placing temporary display cages along the trail to give visitors the opportunity to have a close look at birds. They also built rehabilitation cages for injured birds and just finished constructing a quite large outdoor amphitheater where birds and educational programs can be presented to the public.

I had the opportunity to tour the facility with Mrs. Pat Marcum, executive director, and not only did I see birds that I had never seen close before or at all, but also I learned more about birds of prey in two hours than I did in all my biology years at school.

Pat loves birds, she loves what she does and it shows. We went into the "intensive care unit" where volunteers were force-feeding an injured bird. Pat explained that when a bird arrives at the center, it is treated like any patient would be in a hospital. A bracelet is put around its leg, a treatment card is issued



Linda Dougworth, a volunteer at the Carolina Raptor Center, holds Yaish, a great horned owl.

recording what has been done and what the further treatment will be.

The bird is fed with liquid 3-4 times a day too. Pointing questioningly at a food processor on the counter, with a wink, Pat said: "That is for chocolate mouse." Raptors feed on rats, mice and other small rodents.

Most of the birds at the Center are brought in by volunteers whose job is to pick them up when somebody reports an injured animal. Birds come from all over the United States, many of which have been trapped, shot, electrocuted or struck by cars. A major airline has agreed to fly them for free into Charlotte.

The bird is treated in intensive care, moved into a rehabilitation cage for a while and if not permanently injured, it will be released in its natural habitat.

Although it is difficult with birds in captivity, the center started a reproduction program in 1987. Two years later, a pair of Golden Eagles successfully hatched a chick which was later released into the Georgia mountains.

The reason is it difficult to breed birds in captivity is be-

cause "flying parade" is normally the prelude of the mating process.

Another interesting detail I found out about birds is the "eye imprinting." When a chick opens its eyes for the first time, it will be imprinted with the first moving thing or person that it will see. For the rest of its life, the bird will relate itself with that thing or person. That means that if it is not a bird that first appears in front of the chick, it will make mating impossible in the future.

Some of the birds that have been permanently injured remain at the center and are used for educational purposes. Following the nature trail, you can observe about 20 different species of birds, falcons, hawks, Lancelot, a proud bald eagle, Campbell, a black vulture that "barks" like a dog, Senia, a shy barn owl, Queen Charlotte and Prince Raleigh, a couple of bald eagles that have been shot, and many others.

Hugo, of course, left its print at the center and cages were lost. Again volunteers responded and cleaned and rebuilt. Eagle Scouts are also a big help to the center; one of them is building a huge

cage for its Eagle scout project.

The Carolina Raptor Center actually has two purposes. Their primary goal is education, trying to convince people that they are responsible for what happens in their environment. Problems like foul water or foul air, loss of habitat, pollution, etc., affect people the same way they affect raptors. More than half a million people have been reached so far through programs, workshop and classes presented in the Carolinas and at the center.

Equally important is the center's work with injured raptors. Since 1981, more than 2,700 birds have been treated, approximately 45 percent of them released back into their environment.

How can a non-profit organization make this happen? Strictly through volunteers, donations, corporate sponsoring, etc. Several veterinarians donate their time and supplies to provide care, X-rays and surgery for the injured birds. The center has a roster of about 170 volunteers. Eighty of them are "transport" volunteers and the rest assume tasks such as rehabilitation, education, general maintenance, office workers, fund-raisers, gift shop manning, etc.

New volunteers are always welcome. They will be trained on site at the center. After receiving a general orientation, they will attend a basic training workshop consisting of anatomy of the birds and identification of the Carolinas raptors. They will start working with a "shadow," senior volunteers who will teach them how to handle the birds, feed them, clean cages or how to put on an exhibit, do the office work or any other task. The volunteer will then select the particular field in which he or she wishes to specialize.

Other ways to help the Carolina Raptor Center include memberships, "adopt-a-bird program," donations of material, etc. A



Dumbo, a barred owl, was raised by people and is unable to survive in wild.

walk-in freezer is badly needed.

Lake Wylie residents can contact Jim Arthur of River Hills, who is a board member of the center. Jim is so enthusiastic about the center and he will be delighted to give you more information. The other alternative is to contact directly the Carolina Raptor Center at (704) 875-6521. The only requirement, and there is no exception, is to be 16 years old.

But even if you do not think you can help, my best recommendation would be for you to take a trip there. It is fun, it is educational, it is free, and you will not regret it.

The center is open April 1 to Nov. 30, Wednesday through Sunday, noon to 5 p.m. and Dec. 1 to March 31, Saturday and Sunday, noon to 5 p.m.

LW Chamber gets \$3,500 in state funds

Lake Wylie Chamber of Commerce has been awarded \$3,500 by the South Carolina Department of Parks, Recreation and Tourism for the 1991-92 Tourism-Sharing Projects.

The award specifies \$1,500

grant for advertising Lake Wylie's Spring Splash next year and \$2,000 to produce a Lake Wylie Brochure promoting the event and the area as a tourist attraction.

Slim

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days a week with subjects who combined 15 minutes of aerobic activity with 15 minutes of strength (weight) training.

It was found that after eight weeks, those who had included weight training in their regimen

lost twice as much weight as the others. Especially significant was that while the aerobic exercisers lost three pounds of fat and 1/2 pound of muscle, the combination group lost an average of 10 pounds of fat, while gaining two pounds of muscle. Right on!